

Seven Thinkers on Mediated and Hidden Power: A Comprehensive Research Dossier for the Ariel App Essay

TL;DR

- **The seven form a coherent intellectual lineage about how power hides itself in the apparently neutral medium.** McLuhan and Latour show that media and artifacts are never passive conveyors but actively script behavior; Marx and Debord show that something — labor, social relations, real life — is occluded behind the "neutral" commodity or image; Foucault, Deleuze, and Han narrate the historical mutation of this hidden power from disciplinary enclosure (1700s-1900s) to control-by-modulation (post-1970) to neoliberal self-exploitation (today).
 - **The most deployable core quotes** for the Ariel app's design rationale are: McLuhan's "the medium is the message" (*Understanding Media*, 1964, ch. 1), Latour's "technology is society made durable" (1991) and the speed-bump/door-closer parables, Marx's "fantastic form of a relation between things" (*Capital I*, ch. 1, §4), Debord's thesis 4 ("a social relation between people that is mediated by images"), Foucault's "visibility is a trap" (*Discipline and Punish*, Sheridan p. 200), Deleuze's "self-deforming cast" of modulation (*October 59*, 1992, p. 4), and Han's "freedom itself, which is supposed to be the opposite of constraint, is producing coercion" (*Psychopolitics*). Each says, in its own register: *the face of power has been removed, and the apparatus pretends to be a mere thing*.
 - **Several user-flagged facts are confirmed.** "We shape our tools and thereafter our tools shape us" is **John M. Culkin, S.J.** ("A Schoolman's Guide to Marshall McLuhan," *Saturday Review*, March 18, 1967, p. 70), not McLuhan; Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* is **1975** (Gallimard); Deleuze's "Postscript" first appeared in *L'Autre Journal* no. 1 (**May 1990**), with the canonical English translation by Martin Joughin in *October 59* (**Winter 1992**), pp. 3-7; Han's *Psychopolitik* is **2014 in German** (S. Fischer), 2017 in English (Verso, trans. Erik Butler). (Scribd)
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Key Findings

1. The **"medium is never neutral" claim** has two distinct philosophical pedigrees the essay should not conflate. McLuhan's claim is *phenomenological/perceptual* — media restructure the human sensorium and create new environments. Latour's is *ontological/political* — artifacts carry "scripts," "delegations," and "prescriptions" that act on us with the force of small congealed laws. Both reach the same practical conclusion (artifacts have politics) by different routes.

2. **The "something hidden" claim is Marxist in shape, even when post-Marxist in vocabulary.** Debord explicitly *détourne*s Marx's opening sentence of *Capital* in his own thesis 1, and his thesis 24 is annotated by Knabb as a direct echo of Lukács's *History and Class Consciousness*. Han, despite his Heideggerian register, returns repeatedly to a critique of neoliberal capital. The Ariel app's premise that "faceless power has a face" is a structural restaging of commodity fetishism: the apparatus presents itself as a thing but is in fact a frozen social relation.
 3. **The Foucault → Deleuze → Han arc is a historical periodization, not a refutation chain.** Deleuze explicitly calls his essay a "postscript" — building on, not refuting, Foucault. Han claims to supersede Foucault but his strongest academic critics (Alphin and Debrix, "Biopolitics in the 'Psychic Realm'," *Philosophy & Social Criticism*, 2023) argue that Foucault's 1978–79 *Birth of Biopolitics* lectures (Collège de France; Palgrave 2008) already analyzed *homo oeconomicus* and the entrepreneurial subject Han claims as his "achievement subject." The Ariel essay should treat the arc as cumulative diagnosis, not progressive refutation. (The Conversation + 2)
 4. **For the app's design rationale, the most useful conceptual pairing is Latour + Han.** Latour gives the language of *delegation* (we have offloaded moral judgment to artifacts that pretend to be mere tools); Han gives the language of *smart power* (the friendliest interfaces are the most coercive precisely because they look like freedom). Re-attaching a face to faceless power is, in Latour's terms, *un-delegating*; in Han's terms, *making power visible enough to refuse*.
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Details

1. Marshall McLuhan (1911–1980)

A. Biographical and intellectual context. Herbert Marshall McLuhan was born in Edmonton, raised in Winnipeg, took degrees at the University of Manitoba, then enrolled at Trinity Hall, Cambridge in autumn 1934 as an "affiliated" undergraduate, earning a second BA in 1936; his Cambridge PhD was accepted in 1943 for the dissertation "The Place of Thomas Nashe in the Learning of His Time" (advisor F.P. Wilson). At Cambridge he absorbed the New Criticism of I.A. Richards and F.R. Leavis — meaning his roots are in close attention to the *form* of literary artifacts, not their content. He converted to Catholicism in 1937 (a fact his critics return to: Jonathan Miller calls his thought a "Crypto-Christendom"). He taught at the University of Toronto from 1946 until his death and became, with Harold Innis, Edmund Carpenter, and Eric Havelock, the core of the **Toronto School of Communication Theory**. He was responding to two problems: (i) how to think about radio, film, and television without lapsing into either moralism or technocratic enthusiasm, and (ii) how to extend Innis's work on the political consequences of communications media (*Empire and Communications*, 1950; *The Bias of Communication*, 1951) into a phenomenology of perception. (Wikipedia + 4)

- *The Mechanical Bride: Folklore of Industrial Man* (1951) — a critical reading of advertising as folklore. (Wikipedia)
- *The Gutenberg Galaxy: The Making of Typographic Man* (1962) — argues the print revolution produced the linear, individualist subject of modernity. **Highly relevant.**
- *Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man* (McGraw-Hill, 1964) — chapter 1 "The Medium Is the Message," chapter 2 "Media Hot and Cold." **The single most relevant text.**
- *The Medium Is the Masses: An Inventory of Effects* (with Quentin Fiore, 1967) — illustrated companion volume.
- *War and Peace in the Global Village* (1968).
- *Laws of Media: The New Science* (with Eric McLuhan, posthumous, 1988) — the **tetrad** of media effects.

C. Core concepts in depth.

- **The medium is the message.** Not that content doesn't exist, but that the *scale, pace, and pattern* a medium imposes on human affairs matters more than what is transmitted through it. From *Understanding Media* (ch. 1, p. 7): "the personal and social consequences of any medium — that is, of any extension of ourselves — result from the new scale that is introduced into our affairs by each extension of ourselves, or by any new technology." (MIT)
- **The content of a medium is always another medium.** Speech is the content of writing; writing is the content of print; print is the content of telegraph. We never see the medium itself, only what it contains. (Julia Walton)
- **Hot vs. cool media.** Hot = high-definition, low-participation (radio, film, print); cool = low-definition, high-participation (telephone, television, speech). The distinction is empirically thin; McLuhan sometimes reversed his examples.
- **The global village.** Electric media collapse distance and produce a tribal, simultaneous, all-at-once world. Often misread as utopian; McLuhan described it as anxious, retribalized, and prone to violence.
- **Extensions of man.** Every medium is a prosthetic extension of a faculty: the wheel extends the foot, writing extends the eye, electric circuitry extends the central nervous system.
- **The tetrad.** Every medium (a) enhances some capacity, (b) obsolesces some prior medium, (c) retrieves some buried form, and (d) reverses into its opposite when pushed to its limit.
- **Figure and ground.** Every medium operates as an invisible *ground* against which content appears as *figure*. Critique must make the ground visible.
- **Media as environments.** Media are environments we inhabit, not objects we use; they become invisible by virtue of pervasiveness.

D. Direct quotes.

- "In a culture like ours, long accustomed to splitting and dividing all things as a means of control, it is sometimes a bit of a shock to be reminded that, in operational and practical fact, the medium is the message." — *Understanding Media*, ch. 1, p. 7 (MIT Press ed.). (MIT)
- "The 'content' of a medium is like the juicy piece of meat carried by the burglar to distract the watchdog of the mind." — *Understanding Media*, ch. 1. (Substack)
- "The 'content' of writing or print is speech, but the reader is almost entirely unaware either of print or speech." — *Understanding Media*, p. 25. (Chelsea Tyler)
- **NOT McLuhan:** "We shape our tools and thereafter they shape us" is **John M. Culkin, S.J.**, "A Schoolman's Guide to Marshall McLuhan," *Saturday Review*, March 18, 1967, pp. 51–53 and 70–72; the quoted sentence is on p. 70, glossing McLuhan's postulate "Life imitates art." The misattribution is universally documented at Quote Investigator and the McLuhan Galaxy archive. (Quote Investigator) (Quote Investigator)

E. Connection to the through-line. McLuhan supplies the foundational claim that **the apparatus is never a passive conveyor**. Every interface a designer builds is an environment that restructures perception before any "content" is ever delivered. The Ariel app, by making the face of power visible, is — in McLuhan's terms — *making the ground figure*: forcing the invisible environment to appear as an object of attention.

F. Major critiques.

- **Technological determinism** — Raymond Williams, *Television: Technology and Cultural Form* (Fontana, 1974, pp. 126–128): McLuhan's view "is an apparently sophisticated technological determinism which has the significant effect of indicating a social and cultural determinism.... The initial formulation — 'the medium is the message' — was a simple formalism. The subsequent formulation — 'the medium is the massage' — is a direct and functioning ideology." Williams's point: by making the medium the cause, McLuhan strips away history, capital, and intention. (The Ohio State University)
- **Aphoristic and unscientific** — Jonathan Miller, *McLuhan* (Fontana Modern Masters, 1971), famously writes that he cannot remember "a single observation which I now hold to be true, nor indeed a single theory which even begins to hold water," yet credits McLuhan with productive provocation. Miller reads McLuhan as essentially a religious thinker (Teilhard de Chardin, Southern Agrarians) masquerading as a scientist; the "global village" is a "Crypto-Christendom." (Goodreads)
- **Empirical thinness of hot/cool** — sympathetic readers concede this.

G. Relationships. Decisive influence from **Harold Innis** (whom McLuhan called his master); the Toronto School connection to Carpenter and Havelock. **Baudrillard** read McLuhan closely and extended him into the theory of simulation; **Friedrich Kittler** turned McLuhan into hardware-oriented German media theory. Latour's "actor" concept does work analogous to McLuhan's "extensions" although Latour rarely cites him.

2. Bruno Latour (1947–2022)

A. Biographical and intellectual context. Born in Beaune, Burgundy, into a wine-making family (Maison Louis Latour). Trained in philosophy and theology before doing fieldwork in Côte d'Ivoire on labor and industrial development. His ethnographic study of the Salk Institute (with Steve Woolgar) became *Laboratory Life* (1979) — a foundational text of Science and Technology Studies. Taught at the École des Mines and then Sciences Po Paris; later directed the medialab and curated major exhibitions at ZKM Karlsruhe. He turned increasingly to ecological politics in his late work (*Down to Earth*, 2018; *Facing Gaia*, 2017). He **died of pancreatic cancer on October 9, 2022, in Paris, aged 75** (Encyclopædia Britannica). [\(Encyclopedia Britannica\)](#) [\(Wikipedia\)](#)

B. Major works.

- *Laboratory Life* (with Steve Woolgar, Princeton UP, 1979/1986).
- *Science in Action* (Harvard UP, 1987).
- *The Pasteurization of France* (Harvard UP, 1988).
- "Mixing Humans and Nonhumans Together: The Sociology of a Door-Closer," published under the pseudonym **Jim Johnson**, *Social Problems* 35:3 (June 1988), pp. 298–310. **Critical.** [\(Tumblr\)](#)
- "Technology Is Society Made Durable," in John Law (ed.), *A Sociology of Monsters: Essays on Power, Technology and Domination*, Sociological Review Monograph No. 38, Routledge, 1991, pp. 103–131. **Critical.** [\(Bruno-latour\)](#)
- *We Have Never Been Modern* (French 1991; Harvard UP, Catherine Porter trans., 1993). [\(Wikipedia\)](#)
- "Where Are the Missing Masses? The Sociology of a Few Mundane Artifacts," in Wiebe Bijker and John Law (eds.), *Shaping Technology/Building Society*, MIT Press, 1992, pp. 225–258. **Critical — the speed-bump essay.** [\(Sage Journals\)](#)
- *Aramis, or the Love of Technology* (French 1992; Harvard UP, Catherine Porter trans., 1996).
- *Pandora's Hope* (Harvard UP, 1999).
- "Why Has Critique Run Out of Steam? From Matters of Fact to Matters of Concern," *Critical Inquiry* 30:2 (Winter 2004), pp. 225–248.
- *Reassembling the Social: An Introduction to Actor-Network Theory* (Oxford UP, 2005).
- *Facing Gaia* (Polity, 2017); *Down to Earth* (Polity, 2018).

C. Core concepts.

- **Actor-Network Theory (ANT)** — society is not a stable container but the temporary stabilization of heterogeneous networks of human and non-human *actants*. [\(SozTheo\)](#)

- **The symmetry principle.** Humans and non-humans should be analyzed in the same vocabulary. A door, a microbe, and an engineer are all actants when they make a difference in a network.
- **Scripts and delegation.** Engineers *inscribe* a program of action into an artifact, which then *delegates* the disciplinary task formerly performed by a policeman or a sign to a lump of concrete.
- **Prescription.** What the artifact then demands back from its users — "the moral and ethical dimension of mechanisms" (Johnson 1988, p. 301). (Reading Department)
- **Translation.** The continuous process of converting one actor's interests into the language and form of another.
- **Immutable mobiles.** Artifacts (maps, charts, photographs) that can move across contexts without changing form, enabling action at a distance.
- **The Parliament of Things.** From *We Have Never Been Modern* — a normative proposal for political representation of non-humans. (Wikipedia)
- **Modernity as purification + hybridization.** The modern constitution officially purifies nature from society while proliferating hybrids in practice — hence "we have never been modern." (SozTheo)
- **Matters of fact vs. matters of concern** (2004) — the late Latour's move from deconstruction toward an ethics of "care" for fragile constructions.

D. Direct quotes.

From "*Where Are the Missing Masses?*" (1992): "To balance our accounts of society, we simply have to turn our exclusive attention away from humans and look also at nonhumans. Here they are, the hidden and despised social masses who make up the morality. They knock at the door of sociology, requesting a place in the accounts of society as stubbornly as the human masses did in the nineteenth century." On the speed bump: "there is another radical, nonfigurative solution: the road bumper, or a speed trap that we call in French 'un gendarme couché,' a laid policeman. It is impossible for us not to slow down, or else we break our suspension." The engineering of the speed bump translates the driver's program of action ("don't endanger people") into a different one ("don't break your suspension"); either way the disciplinary outcome is achieved. The artifact makes the policeman's labor durable, congealed in concrete. (Conceptlab + 2)

From "*Mixing Humans and Nonhumans Together*" (Jim Johnson [Bruno Latour], *Social Problems* 35:3, June 1988, pp. 298–310): The essay opens from a hand-written sign reading "The door-closer is on strike, for God's sake, keep the door closed." Latour treats the door as an asymmetry-producing wall and then walks through the cascade of delegations required to keep a door closed: discipline the humans (unreliable), hire a doorman (expensive), or delegate the task to a hydraulic spring (cheap but rude — it slams in children's faces). His concluding formulation: "If, in our societies, there are thousands of such lieutenants to which we have delegated competences, it means that what defines our social relations is, for the most part, prescribed back to us by nonhumans. Knowledge, morality, craft, force, sociability are not properties of humans

but of humans accompanied by their retinue of delegated characters. Since each of those delegates ties together part of our social world, it means that studying social relations without the nonhumans is impossible." The pseudonym "Jim Johnson, Columbus Ohio School of Mines" was adopted at the editors' insistence that French references be removed; Latour reveals the joke in the footnotes. (Innovation-change + 4)

"*Technology is society made durable*" — the title and central thesis of the 1991 chapter in Law's *Sociology of Monsters* (pp. 103–131): social order is not held together by "social" forces alone; it requires the enrollment of non-human actors (walls, locks, contracts inscribed on paper, hydraulic mechanisms) that make ephemeral asymmetries persist over time. Power is durable because it is embodied in materials humans cannot easily renegotiate. (Bruno-latour + 2)

From "*Why Has Critique Run Out of Steam?*" (*Critical Inquiry*, Winter 2004, pp. 226–227): "I myself have spent some time in the past trying to show 'the lack of scientific certainty' inherent in the construction of facts. I too made it a 'primary issue.' But I did not exactly aim at fooling the public by obscuring the certainty of a closed argument — or did I? After all, I have been accused of just that sin.... Was I foolishly mistaken? Have things changed so fast?" Later in the essay: "The critic is not the one who debunks, but the one who assembles. The critic is not the one who lifts the rugs from under the feet of the naive believers, but the one who offers the participants arenas in which to gather." (Dsimian) (New Humanist)

On Aramis: Aramis, or the Love of Technology (Harvard UP, 1996) is a postmortem of a Paris personal rapid transit (PRT) project that ran from 1969 to 1987 — small electronically coupled cars that would platoon and split for individual destinations. Officially it died because electronic couplings proved too complex and political will failed; Latour's deeper claim is that **Aramis failed because no network of human and non-human actors loved it enough to sustain it**. He writes the book as "scientifiction" — a "hybrid genre for a hybrid task" (preface, p. ix) — combining detective novel, sociological commentary, archival documents, and the voice of the failed technology itself speaking in the first person. (Amazon) (Wikipedia)

E. Connection to the through-line. Latour gives the most rigorous available account of how power *delegates itself into things* and thereby disappears. Every "neutral" widget — every speed bump, captcha, default setting, push notification — is the materialization of a program of action that was once a face-to-face demand. The Ariel app's project is, in Latour's framework, the project of making the delegated chain visible again so users can renegotiate it.

F. Major critiques.

- **Flat ontology / loss of critique** — David Bloor's "Anti-Latour" (*Studies in History and Philosophy of Science*, 1999) argues that giving non-humans symmetrical agency dissolves the distinction between social explanation and natural fact.
- **Conservative implications** — Critics including Langdon Winner argue ANT's refusal to take normative positions makes it complicit with whatever network it describes.

- **Self-critique on post-truth** — Latour himself in the 2004 *Critical Inquiry* essay confessed that science studies had been weaponized by climate deniers and conspiracy theorists who imitate the form of constructivist critique to attack legitimate science.
- **Sokal and Bricmont**, *Fashionable Nonsense* (1997), lumped Latour into a broader attack on French theory; he largely escapes the specific charges but the polemic dogged him.

G. Relationships. Influenced by **Michel Serres** (philosophy of mediation), Harold Garfinkel (ethnomethodology), Greimassian semiotics, **Gabriel Tarde** (rediscovered as an alternative to Durkheim), and Michel Callon and John Law as collaborators. Latour was hostile to most Marxist critical theory; his relation to Foucault is courteous but distant — both think power as relational, but Latour explicitly rejects the focus on discipline and discourse in favor of materials. [\(Wikipedia\)](#)

3. Karl Marx (1818-1883)

A. Biographical and intellectual context. Born in Trier, Prussia, into an assimilated Jewish family that converted to Lutheranism. Studied at Bonn and Berlin (Young Hegelians); doctoral dissertation on Democritus and Epicurus. Edited the *Rheinische Zeitung* until censorship; emigrated to Paris, Brussels, finally London (1849), where he spent the rest of his life writing in the British Museum. Lifelong intellectual partnership with Engels. *Das Kapital*, *Band I* published 1867 (Hamburg, Verlag von Otto Meissner). Died in London 1883.

B. Major works. *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844* (alienation texts; published 1932); *The German Ideology* (with Engels, 1846; published 1932); *The Communist Manifesto* (1848); *Grundrisse* (1857-58; published 1939); *A Contribution to the Critique of Political Economy* (1859); *Capital*, *Vol. I* (1867); *Capital*, *Vols. II and III* (posthumous, ed. Engels, 1885, 1894). **For the through-line: Capital Vol. I, Chapter 1, Section 4, "The Fetishism of the Commodity and Its Secret."** [\(Philopedia\)](#)

C. Core concepts (only those bearing on the through-line).

- **Use-value vs. exchange-value.** A commodity has *use-value* (concrete utility — a coat keeps you warm) and *exchange-value* (its quantitative ratio to other commodities). Capitalism privileges exchange-value.
- **The labor theory of value (background).** A commodity's exchange-value is determined by the "socially necessary labor time" required for its production. [\(Politicalaffairs\)](#)
- **Commodity fetishism** (*Capital I*, ch. 1, §4). In capitalism, social relations between producers *appear* to people as relations between things. The objective social relation is real, but misperceived as a property of the things themselves. [\(The Philosophical Salon\)](#)
- **Alienation** (more central to the 1844 Manuscripts): the worker is estranged from the product, from the act of labor, from species-being, and from other workers.

- **Reification (Verdinglichung)** — extended by **Georg Lukács** in *History and Class Consciousness* (1923), "Reification and the Consciousness of the Proletariat." Lukács generalizes commodity fetishism into a universal cognitive structure of capitalist society — the way commodity logic seeps into law, bureaucracy, science, and consciousness itself. This is the decisive bridge from Marx to Debord. (Communists in Situ)

D. Direct quotes. The canonical passage from *Capital* Vol. I, ch. 1, §4, in the older Moore/Aveling translation:

"There, the existence of the things *qua* commodities, and the value relation between the products of labour which stamps them as commodities, have absolutely no connexion with their physical properties and with the material relations arising therefrom. There it is a definite social relation between men, that assumes, in their eyes, the fantastic form of a relation between things. In order, therefore, to find an analogy, we must have recourse to the mist-enveloped regions of the religious world. In that world the productions of the human brain appear as independent beings endowed with life, and entering into relation both with one another and the human race. So it is in the world of commodities with the products of men's hands. This I call the Fetishism which attaches itself to the products of labour, so soon as they are produced as commodities, and which is therefore inseparable from the production of commodities."

The Ben Fowkes translation (Penguin, 1976, p. 165) renders the key clause: "It is nothing but the definite social relation between men themselves which assumes here, for them, the fantastic form of a relation between things." Opening sentence of *Capital* (Fowkes p. 125): "The wealth of societies in which the capitalist mode of production prevails appears as an immense collection of commodities." (The Philosophical Salon)

E. Connection to the through-line. Marx supplies the structural logic every later thinker assumes: **what appears as a relation between things is in fact a relation between people.** The Ariel app's premise — that there is a face behind the algorithm, a person behind the corporate decision, a labor process behind the interface — is a literal application of commodity fetishism to the platform economy.

F. Major critiques.

- **Transformation problem** — Eugen von Böhm-Bawerk (*Karl Marx and the Close of His System*, 1896) argued the labor theory of value is mathematically incompatible with the equalization of profit rates across industries.
- **Marginalist revolution** — Menger, Jevons, Walras argued value is determined by subjective marginal utility, not labor time. Mainstream economics largely accepts this.
- **Post-structuralist critiques** — Althusser argued for an "epistemological break" between young (humanist) and mature (structural) Marx; later poststructuralists worry that commodity fetishism rests on a problematic distinction between "real" and "apparent" relations.

- **Value-form theory** (Michael Heinrich, Moishe Postone) — defends fetishism but rejects cruder labor-embodiment readings.

G. Relationships. Hegel is the philosophical scaffold (the inversion, the *verkehrte Welt*).

Feuerbach supplies the template of religious projection — fetishism is *The Essence of Christianity* applied to commodities. **Lukács** is the decisive transmission belt to Debord.

Foucault's relation to Marx is complicated — he insisted he was not a Marxist but treated Marx as part of the air everyone breathed in mid-century French thought.

4. Guy Debord (1931–1994)

A. Biographical and intellectual context. Born in Paris; his father died young; he grew up between Italy and the south of France. Arrived in Paris in the early 1950s, joined the Lettrist International, and in 1957 co-founded the **Situationist International** (SI), which lasted until 1972 and included Asger Jorn, Raoul Vaneigem, Constant Nieuwenhuys, and (briefly) many figures he eventually expelled. The SI was a revolutionary avant-garde aiming to fuse the Marxist critique of alienation with surrealist and Dada techniques. Debord made several films (*Howls for Sade*, 1952; *The Society of the Spectacle*, 1973). He played a significant if often overstated role in May 1968. After 1972 he became increasingly reclusive, drinking heavily; he shot himself on November 30, 1994.

B. Major works.

- "Theory of the Dérive" (*Internationale Situationniste* no. 2, 1958).
- "Report on the Construction of Situations" (1957).
- ***La Société du spectacle*** (Buchet-Chastel, Paris, 1967). English translations: Fredy Perlman et al. (Black & Red, 1970/1977); Donald Nicholson-Smith (Zone Books, 1994); Ken Knabb (Bureau of Public Secrets, 2002/2014; PM Press 2024).
- ***Commentaires sur la société du spectacle*** / *Comments on the Society of the Spectacle* (1988; Verso English ed., Malcolm Imrie trans., 1990) — introduces the "integrated spectacle." [Leftwingbooks](#) [Leftwingbooks](#)
- *Panegyric* (1989) — his memoir.
- *In girum imus nocte et consumimur igni* (1978 film).

C. Core concepts.

- **The spectacle.** Not "media" or "images" per se, but a stage of capitalist development in which social relations between people are systematically mediated by, and lived as, images.
- **The concentrated spectacle** (Soviet bloc, fascist regimes): a single image of the leader dominates.

- **The diffuse spectacle** (Western liberal capitalism): a plurality of competing commodity-images.
- **The integrated spectacle** — introduced in *Comments* (1988): the two have fused; the spectacle now integrates surveillance, secrecy, terrorism, and PR into a single seamless apparatus. (Leftwingbooks)
- **Détournement** — the appropriation and modification of existing cultural materials (comic strips, films, slogans) to invert their meaning. The SI's signature technique.
- **The dérive** ("drift") — psychogeographic exploration through urban environments to discover the unconscious affective geography produced by capital and planning.
- **Psychogeography** — the study of how the geographic environment affects emotions and behavior.
- **Recuperation** — the process by which capital absorbs and neutralizes radical critique by turning it into commodity.

D. Direct quotes (Knabb 2014/2024 translation, Bureau of Public Secrets).

- **Thesis 1:** "In societies where modern conditions of production prevail, life is presented as an immense accumulation of *spectacles*. Everything that was directly lived has receded into a representation." (Knabb's annotation: directly détourné from the opening of *Capital*: "The wealth of societies in which the capitalist mode of production prevails presents itself as an immense accumulation of commodities.") (bopsecrets) (bopsecrets)
- **Thesis 4:** "The spectacle is not a collection of images; it is a social relation between people that is mediated by images." (Knabb's annotation: détournement of *Capital* Vol. I, ch. 33: "Capital is not a thing; it is a social relationship between people that is mediated by things.") (bopsecrets) (bopsecrets)
- **Thesis 9:** "In a world that has really been turned upside down, the true is a moment of the false." (Détourné from Hegel's *Phenomenology*: "The false is a moment of the true.") (bopsecrets) (bopsecrets)
- **Thesis 17:** "The first stage of the economy's domination of social life brought about an evident degradation of *being* into *having*.... The present stage... is bringing about a general shift from *having* to *appearing*." (bopsecrets) (Wikipedia)
- **Thesis 24:** "The fetishistic appearance of pure objectivity in spectacular relations conceals their true character as relations between people and between classes." (Knabb cites Lukács's *History and Class Consciousness*, Livingstone trans., MIT Press, p. 14: "The fetishistic illusions enveloping all phenomena in capitalist society... conceal the fact that they are the categories of the *relations of men with each other*.") (bopsecrets + 2)
- **Thesis 30:** "The more he contemplates, the less he lives; the more he identifies with the dominant images of need, the less he understands his own life and his own desires." (bopsecrets)

- **Thesis 34:** "The spectacle is *capital* accumulated to the point that it becomes image."

bopsecrets

The **Nicholson-Smith (Zone Books, 1994)** translation renders thesis 4: "The spectacle is not a collection of images; rather, it is a social relationship between people that is mediated by images." Use Knabb for accuracy + accessibility; Nicholson-Smith for academic citation; Perlman (Black & Red, freely online) is rougher.

E. Connection to the through-line. Debord is the great theorist of **what is hidden behind the apparently neutral image**. The spectacle does not lie about specific facts; it lies about the *form of life* itself by reducing it to representation. For the Ariel essay, Debord is the bridge between Marx (something is hidden) and Han (the hiding now goes through self-exposure rather than concealment). Debord's spectacle was a one-way unilateral image; Han's transparency society is bidirectional and participatory.

F. Major critiques.

- **Totality / hermeticism** — Debord writes as if there is no outside the spectacle, which makes the source of his own critical leverage unclear.
- **Empirical thinness** — like McLuhan, he proceeds by aphorism.
- **Postmodern absorption** — Baudrillard's simulacra and Jameson's "cultural logic of late capitalism" extend Debord in directions he would have hated (he despised Baudrillard).
- **Does spectacle theory still apply?** — Under platform capitalism, users are not passive spectators but active producers of content. This is exactly the question Han takes up.

G. Relationships. **Anselm Jappe**, *Guy Debord* (University of California Press, 1999, trans. Donald Nicholson-Smith, foreword by T.J. Clark; PM Press reprint 2018) is the indispensable secondary source. Jappe argues Debord is "an heir of the young Georg Lukács of *History and Class Consciousness*," not (as is sometimes claimed) a precursor of Baudrillard. The chapter "Debord and Lukács" (p. 19ff) is the locus classicus. **Lukács** is the decisive philosophical influence; through Lukács, Debord is reading **Hegel** and **Marx**. **Henri Lefebvre's** *Critique of Everyday Life* and his sociology of urban space are immediate influences. The Surrealists and Dadaists are the artistic genealogy. (PhilPapers) (Libcom)

5. Michel Foucault (1926–1984)

A. Biographical and intellectual context. Born in Poitiers; trained at the ENS (1946); deeply marked by Hyppolite's teaching of Hegel and by encounters with Althusser, Canguilhem, and Dumézil. Studied psychology and philosophy; his early work used what he called "archaeology" to examine the historical conditions of possibility for various forms of knowledge. After May 1968, he became politically active — co-founding the **GIP (Groupe d'Information sur les**

Prisons) with Deleuze and others in 1971. Held the chair in "History of Systems of Thought" at the Collège de France from 1970 until his death from AIDS-related illness on June 25, 1984.

B. Major works.

- *Madness and Civilization / History of Madness* (1961).
- *The Birth of the Clinic* (1963).
- *The Order of Things* (1966).
- *The Archaeology of Knowledge* (1969).
- ***Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*** (*Surveiller et punir: Naissance de la prison*, Gallimard, 1975; English trans. Alan Sheridan, Pantheon, 1977). **The single most relevant work.**
- *The History of Sexuality, Vol. I: The Will to Knowledge* (1976) — introduces biopower.
- *The History of Sexuality, Vols. II & III* (1984).
- *Society Must Be Defended* (Collège de France lectures 1975–76, published 1997).
- ***The Birth of Biopolitics*** (Collège de France lectures 1978–79, published 2004; Palgrave English ed. 2008) — the analysis of neoliberalism that anticipates much of what Han later claims as new.
- "Governmentality" (lecture, 1978).

C. Core concepts.

- **Power/knowledge** (pouvoir/savoir). Power and knowledge are not separable; every form of knowledge implies a regime of power and vice versa. (HUBSOCIOLOGY)
- **Productive power.** Power is not merely repressive (forbidding, censoring, exiling) but *productive*: it produces subjects, bodies, desires, identities, discourses. (Homo Hortus)
- **Relational power.** Power is not a thing one possesses but a relation that circulates through the social body. (Homo Hortus)
- **Disciplinary power.** A specific historical formation (17th–20th centuries) operating through enclosure, partition, examination, surveillance, and normalization.
- **The Panopticon.** Bentham's prison design, taken by Foucault as the *diagram* of disciplinary power. The prisoner is always visible to a watcher who cannot be verified to be watching. Result: self-disciplining. (Medium) (Medium)
- **Docile bodies.** Bodies "that may be subjected, used, transformed and improved."
- **Examination.** The combination of hierarchical surveillance and normalizing judgment in a single ritual.
- **Normalization.** Production of "the normal" as a statistical and moral category.
- **Biopower.** Targets populations rather than individual bodies; statistics, public health, demographic management. Sovereign power "made die and let live"; biopower "makes live and lets die" (*Society Must Be Defended*, lecture of 17 March 1976).

- **Governmentality.** The conduct of conduct — the ensemble of institutions, procedures, calculations, and tactics through which populations are governed. Crucial for Foucault's later analysis of liberalism and neoliberalism. (Homo Hortus)

D. Direct quotes. From *Discipline and Punish* (Sheridan trans., Vintage/Pantheon 1977/1995), the "Panopticism" chapter:

- "Hence the major effect of the Panopticon: to induce in the inmate a state of conscious and permanent visibility that assures the automatic functioning of power." (p. 201)
- "He who is subjected to a field of visibility, and who knows it, assumes responsibility for the constraints of power; he makes them play spontaneously upon himself; he inscribes in himself the power relation in which he simultaneously plays both roles; he becomes the principle of his own subjection." (pp. 202–203)
- "Visibility is a trap." (p. 200) (SparkNotes)
- "The Panopticon is a marvellous machine which, whatever use one may wish to put it to, produces homogeneous effects of power." (p. 202)
- On productive power (p. 194): "We must cease once and for all to describe the effects of power in negative terms: it 'excludes,' it 'represses,' it 'censors,' it 'abstracts,' it 'masks,' it 'conceals.' In fact, power produces; it produces reality; it produces domains of objects and rituals of truth."

From *The History of Sexuality, Vol. I* (Hurley trans., Pantheon, 1978):

- "Power is everywhere; not because it embraces everything, but because it comes from everywhere." (p. 93)
- "Where there is power, there is resistance, and yet, or rather consequently, this resistance is never in a position of exteriority in relation to power." (p. 95)

E. Connection to the through-line. Foucault provides the historical-philosophical scaffolding for the claim that power has *changed shape* across modernity — from sovereign visibility (the public execution) to disciplinary internalization (the prisoner who watches himself). For the Ariel app's argument, the Panopticon is the foundational image: when you cannot see who is watching, you assume you are always being watched and discipline yourself accordingly. The app's project of *re-attaching a face* is the inverse move — making the watcher visible so the asymmetry of the Panopticon collapses.

F. Major critiques.

- **Habermas, *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity*** (MIT Press, trans. Frederick Lawrence, 1987), Lectures IX & X (pp. 238–293, esp. pp. 275–276). Habermas's famous tripartite charge: Foucault's genealogy is **presentistic, relativistic, and cryptonormative**. If all truth-claims are effects of power, Foucault's own claims must be too — a performative

contradiction. The "cryptonormative" charge: Foucault clearly takes sides (against domination, for resistance) while officially refusing any normative ground. (Parrhesiajournal)

- **Nancy Fraser, "Foucault on Modern Power: Empirical Insights and Normative Confusions,"** *Praxis International* 1:3 (October 1981), reprinted in *Unruly Practices* (Minnesota, 1989), pp. 17–34. Fraser grants Foucault a rich empirical account but charges him with calling "too many different sorts of things power" and lacking the normative resources to distinguish "a Salvadorean torture cell" from "a bureaucratic welfare state." (Willmorriseyreviews)
- **Charles Taylor, "Foucault on Freedom and Truth"** (*Political Theory*, 1984) — argues Foucault cannot coherently criticize disciplinary power without smuggling in the very humanism he attacks.
- **Feminist critiques** (Sandra Bartky, Susan Bordo) — the Panopticon model applies powerfully to femininity but Foucault himself was strikingly inattentive to gender.
- **"Everything is power"** — if power is everywhere, the concept becomes useless. Foucault's response: power is *relations*, and analysis of specific relations remains possible.

G. Relationships. Foucault's master was **Canguilhem** (history of science as history of concepts); his rival was **Sartre**; his close ally was **Deleuze** (the GIP). Foucault read **Nietzsche** as the source of the genealogical method. With **Marx**, his relation was distant but not hostile. **Habermas** was his great German antagonist. Deleuze wrote a book-length tribute (*Foucault*, Minuit, 1986) after his death. (Gilles Deleuze)

6. Gilles Deleuze (1925–1995)

A. Biographical and intellectual context. Born in Paris; survived a wartime childhood (his brother died in deportation). Studied at the Sorbonne under Hyppolite, Canguilhem, and Alquié. Taught at Lyon and then, after 1969, at the experimental university Paris VIII–Vincennes, where his seminars were legendary. He suffered from chronic respiratory illness — he had developed tuberculosis in 1968 and undergone lung removal (he was an avid smoker). He **ended his life on November 4, 1995, by jumping from his apartment window, to end a worsening chronic respiratory illness for which he had recently undergone a tracheotomy** (Craig R. Whitney, *New York Times*, November 7, 1995). His major works divide into (i) historical monographs on individual philosophers; (ii) his own systematic philosophy (*Difference and Repetition*, 1968; *The Logic of Sense*, 1969); (iii) joint works with Félix Guattari (*Anti-Oedipus*, 1972; *A Thousand Plateaus*, 1980; *What Is Philosophy?*, 1991). (Wikipedia) (Los Angeles Review of Books)

B. Major works (only those bearing on the through-line).

- *Difference and Repetition* (1968).
- *Anti-Oedipus* (with Guattari, 1972).
- *A Thousand Plateaus* (with Guattari, 1980).

- **Foucault** (Minuit, 1986; Eng. trans. Seán Hand, Minnesota, 1988) — Deleuze's reading of Foucault, written the year after Foucault's death; based on his 1985–86 seminar at Paris VIII (transcripts at deleuze.cla.purdue.edu). ([Gilles Deleuze](#))
- **"Post-scriptum sur les sociétés de contrôle,"** *L'Autre Journal*, no. 1, May 1990. Collected in *Pourparlers 1972–1990* (Minuit, 1990). English: "Postscript on the Societies of Control," trans. **Martin Joughin**, *October*, vol. 59 (Winter 1992), pp. 3–7 (MIT Press). Also in *Negotiations 1972–1990*, Columbia UP, 1995, pp. 177–182, under the slightly different title "Postscript on Control Societies." ([The Anarchist Library](#)) ([Libcom](#))

C. Core concepts.

- **Societies of control.** Deleuze's central periodization claim. Disciplinary societies (18th–early 20th century) operated through *enclosures* — school, barracks, factory, prison, hospital — with the individual passing from one to the next, "always starting again." Control societies (emerging post-WWII, dominant since the 1970s) operate not through enclosure but through *continuous modulation* across porous, networked institutions. ([The Conversation + 2](#))
- **Modulation.** Where discipline molds the subject into a fixed shape, control modulates continuously — like a sound engineer adjusting frequencies — so the subject's shape is never finalized but always being readjusted via feedback (KPIs, credit scores, algorithmic feeds). ([Queensland University of T...](#))
- **The dividual.** In disciplinary societies, the individual was a discrete unit with a signature and number in a mass. In control societies, the individual fragments into a "dividual" — a bundle of data points, scores, profiles — and the mass becomes "samples, data, markets, or 'banks.'" ([Academia.edu](#))
- **Code vs. watchword.** Disciplinary societies are organized by *watchwords* (passwords, mottos that mark membership); control societies by *codes* (numerical credentials that grant or deny access in real time). ([Goodreads](#))
- **Assemblage** (*agencement*) — heterogeneous components held together by contingent relations, not structural necessity.
- **Rhizome** — a non-hierarchical, decentralized structure (vs. arborescent/tree structures).

D. Direct quotes (Joughin trans., *October* 59, 1992, pp. 3–7).

- "Enclosures are molds, distinct castings, but controls are a modulation, like a self-deforming cast that will continuously change from one moment to the other, or like a sieve whose mesh will transmute from point to point." (p. 4) ([Libcom](#))
- "The corporation has replaced the factory, and the corporation is a spirit, a gas." (p. 4) ([Libcom](#))
- "In the disciplinary societies one was always starting again (from school to the barracks, from the barracks to the factory), while in the societies of control one is never finished with

anything — the corporation, the educational system, the armed services being metastable states coexisting in one and the same modulation, like a universal system of deformation." (p. 5)

- "Individuals have become 'dividuals,' and masses, samples, data, markets, or 'banks.'" (p. 5)
- "The disciplinary man was a discontinuous producer of energy, but the man of control is undulatory, in orbit, in a continuous network. Everywhere *surfing* has replaced the older *sports*." (p. 6)
- "We are taught that corporations have a soul, which is the most terrifying news in the world." (Goodreads)
- Closing: "It's not a question of worrying or of hoping for the best, but of finding new weapons."

E. Connection to the through-line. Deleuze provides the crucial historical pivot: Foucault's analysis was already partly out of date by 1990, because power had stopped operating primarily through enclosure and had begun operating through *modulation* — through soft incentive structures, continuous feedback, gamification, real-time personalization. The Ariel app, which surfaces the algorithmic modulation happening to users, is precisely a tool against the "self-deforming cast." Deleuze closes with: "It's not a question of worrying or of hoping for the best, but of finding new weapons." Arguably the design brief.

F. Major critiques.

- **Empirical thinness.** The Postscript is six pages and offers no sustained empirical analysis. Critics (Alexander Galloway, Wendy Hui Kyong Chun) argue the discipline/control distinction is too tidy.
- **Coexistence rather than succession.** Many institutions (prisons, schools) remain disciplinary while new ones (platforms) are control-modulatory.
- **Romantic anti-corporatism.** The Deleuzian vocabulary ("smooth space," "lines of flight," "nomadism") is too easily absorbed into Silicon Valley libertarianism — exactly the recuperation Debord feared.
- **The dividual as overstatement.** Data profiling does not eliminate the legal/political individual; it operates alongside it.

G. Relationships. Deleuze's relation to Foucault is decisive for the through-line. They were close friends and political allies (the GIP) from 1968 until a late-1970s falling-out; Foucault's death in 1984 prompted Deleuze's 1986 *Foucault* and the 1985-86 seminar. The Postscript explicitly extends Foucault and credits William S. Burroughs for the term "control." With Guattari, Deleuze developed the broader apparatus (assemblages, rhizomes) that informs the Postscript even when not directly invoked. (Gilles Deleuze + 2)

7. Byung-Chul Han (b. 1959)

A. Biographical and intellectual context. Born in Seoul; studied metallurgy at Korea University (his own account: he felt like "an idiot" at the end of it). **He arrived in Germany at age 22, without knowing German**, having told his parents he was continuing his scientific studies (Han's own statement, per Wikipedia and *El País* via Aeon Essays, 2023). Studied philosophy, German literature, and Catholic theology at Freiburg and Munich. PhD at Freiburg 1994 on **Stimmung (mood) in Heidegger**. Habilitation at Basel (2000). Taught at the Hochschule für Gestaltung Karlsruhe (HfG) from 2010 and at the **Universität der Künste Berlin (UdK) from 2012**, where he ran the Studium Generale program. He has cultivated a reclusive persona — refusing many interviews, declining to give his date of birth, accusing transparency itself of being totalitarian. His books are short, aphoristic, and prolific (more than thirty volumes); they are bestsellers especially in the Hispanophone world. He was **announced as the recipient of the Princess of Asturias Award for Communication and Humanities on 7 May 2025** by the Fundación Princesa de Asturias, whose jury cited "his brilliance in interpreting the challenges of technological society"; the award drew 47 nominations from 16 countries (Fundación Princesa de Asturias official press release; *Korea Herald*, 7 May 2025). (Wikipedia + 14)

B. Major works (German / English dates).

- *Heideggers Herz* / dissertation on Stimmung (1996).
- *Was ist Macht?* (Reclam, 2005) / *What Is Power?* (Polity, 2018). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Müdigkeitsgesellschaft* (Matthes & Seitz Berlin, **October 4, 2010**) / **The Burnout Society** (Stanford UP, trans. Erik Butler, 2015). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Topologie der Gewalt* (Matthes & Seitz, 2011) / *Topology of Violence* (MIT Press, 2018). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Transparenzgesellschaft* (Matthes & Seitz, 2012) / **The Transparency Society** (Stanford UP, trans. Erik Butler, 2015). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Agonie des Eros* (Matthes & Seitz, 2012) / *The Agony of Eros* (MIT Press, 2017). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Im Schwarm* (Matthes & Seitz, 2013) / **In the Swarm: Digital Prospects** (MIT Press, trans. Erik Butler, 2017). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- **Psychopolitik: Neoliberalismus und die neuen Machttechniken** (S. Fischer, 2014) / **Psychopolitics: Neoliberalism and New Technologies of Power** (Verso, trans. Erik Butler, 2017). **The single most relevant work.** (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Die Austreibung des Anderen* (2016) / *The Expulsion of the Other* (Polity, 2018). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Vom Verschwinden der Rituale* (2019) / *The Disappearance of Rituals* (Polity, 2020). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Undinge* (2021) / *Non-things* (Polity, 2022). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)
- *Infokratie* (2021) / *Infocracy* (Polity, 2022). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)

- *Vita Contemplativa* (2022; English 2024). (Fundación Princesa de Ast...)

C. Core concepts.

- **The achievement society / achievement subject** (Leistungsgesellschaft / Leistungssubjekt). Foucault's disciplinary subject was governed by negative commands ("you should not"). The contemporary subject is governed by positive injunctions ("you can," "yes, we can"). The achievement subject experiences itself as a free entrepreneur but is in fact the slave of an internalized imperative to optimize. (Grokikipedia) (ArtReview)
- **Self-exploitation / auto-exploitation.** Where Marx's worker was exploited by a capitalist, Han's achievement subject exploits itself. (Befreed) (Goodreads)
- **Smart power / friendly power.** Power in the neoliberal regime does not threaten, prohibit, or coerce. It seduces, motivates, and stimulates. It speaks in the voice of Alexa and Siri. (Mohan + 2)
- **Transparency society.** The demand for total openness is not a guarantee of freedom but a regime of control. Where Foucault's Panopticon enforced visibility from a center, Han's transparency society demands all-around mutual visibility — voluntary, participatory, more effective.
- **The swarm.** Digital communication does not produce a public (the modern bourgeois sphere of rational deliberation) but a *swarm* — a leaderless agglomeration without coherent collective subjectivity. Shitstorms, not strikes.
- **Psychopolitics.** Where biopolitics targeted biological life (Foucault), psychopolitics targets the psyche — through emotional data, predictive analytics, nudges, manufactured desire. (Sage Journals) (ICNS Instituto)
- **Positivity vs. negativity.** Contemporary culture is allergic to negativity (the Other, suffering, contemplation, death) and obsessed with positivity (likes, smooth interfaces, productivity). The result is paradoxical exhaustion — burnout of an achievement subject with no negative limits.
- **The disappearance of rituals / expulsion of the Other.** Late Han: rituals (repetitive symbolic forms) gave time depth and community; their disappearance leaves us in a "shallow" time of constant novelty. The Other is being expelled in favor of the "hell of the same." (Substack) (Amazon)
- **Hell of the same** (Hölle des Gleichen) — contemporary digital culture eliminates difference and produces a closed loop of recognition.

D. Direct quotes (*Psychopolitics*, Verso 2017, trans. Erik Butler).

- "The freedom of *Can* generates even more coercion than the disciplinarian *Should*, which issues commandments and prohibitions.... Technically, freedom means the opposite of coercion and compulsion. Being free means being free from constraint. But now freedom itself, which is supposed to be the opposite of constraint, is producing coercion."

- "Today, everyone is an auto-exploiting labourer in his or her own enterprise. People are now master and slave in one. Even class struggle has transformed into an inner struggle against oneself." (Goodreads)
- "Although the achievement-subject deems itself free, in reality it is a slave. In so far as it willingly exploits itself without a master, it is an absolute slave." (Modern Reformation) (Stuartjmurrray)
- "Now, under the neoliberal regime of auto-exploitation, people are turning their aggression against themselves. This auto-aggressivity means that the exploited are not inclined to revolution so much as depression." (Goodreads)
- "Power need not exclude, prohibit or censor.... The greater power is, the more quietly it works. It just happens: it has no need to draw attention to itself." (Stuartjmurrray)

From **The Burnout Society** (Stanford UP, 2015): "The complaint of the depressive individual, 'Nothing is possible,' can only occur in a society that thinks, 'Nothing is impossible.'" "Today's society is no longer Foucault's disciplinary world of hospitals, madhouses, prisons, barracks, and factories. It has long been replaced by another regime, namely a society of fitness studios, office towers, banks, airports, shopping malls, and genetic laboratories." (Goodreads)

(The Courtauld Institute of Art)

From **The Transparency Society** (Stanford UP, 2015): "Only machines are transparent. Eventfulness and freedom, which constitute life fundamentally, do not admit transparency." "A transparent relationship is a dead one, altogether lacking attraction and vitality." (Goodreads)

(Goodreads)

E. Connection to the through-line. Han is the endpoint of the lineage and the most direct match for the Ariel app's premise. His diagnosis: power has *disappeared as power* by adopting the form of freedom itself; we exploit ourselves on platforms that feel like our own choice. The Ariel app, by re-attaching a face to faceless power, does in interface design what Han does in philosophy: surface the agent behind the friendly nudge.

F. Major critiques.

- **Misreading of Foucault.** Caroline Alphin and François Debrix, "Biopolitics in the 'Psychic Realm': Han, Foucault and neoliberal psychopolitics," *Philosophy & Social Criticism*, 2023, argue that Foucault's *Birth of Biopolitics* lectures (1978–79; Palgrave 2008) already analyzed *homo oeconomicus* and the entrepreneurial subject — Han's "achievement subject" is largely repackaged late Foucault. (Sage Journals)
- **Repetition and aphorism.** Stuart Jeffries (*The Guardian*, 18 February 2024, on *The Crisis of Narration*) writes that Han "writes as though he's never been contradicted" — calling the book "an entertaining polemic that's short on humility." Cevat Karataş, "Toward a Critique of Critique: Paradoxes of Byung-Chul Han," *Constellations* (Wiley, 2025), argues Han's

"brevity, repetition, and accessibility... jeopardize the reproduction of the temporal dynamics it seeks to problematize." (Ourdailyread) (Wiley Online Library)

- **Cultural conservatism / nostalgia.** Reviewers note Han's vocabulary (ritual, contemplation, the Other, *Stimmung*) draws on a Heideggerian conservative tradition. Han himself rejects the nostalgia charge in his ArtReview interview: "my analyses have nothing to do with nostalgia." (ArtReview)
- **Empirical thinness.** Like McLuhan, Debord, and Deleuze, Han proceeds by aphorism — no original sociology, interviews, or statistics.
- **The Hispanosphere paradox.** Adrian Nathan West (Los Angeles Review of Books, "Media and Transparency: An Introduction to Byung-Chul Han in English") notes Han's books are extraordinarily popular in Spanish translation, raising the question whether the appetite is itself a symptom of what he describes.

G. Relationships. Heidegger is the bedrock (Han's dissertation; concepts of dwelling, contemplative time, the question of the Other). Hegel appears in the books on negativity. Foucault is the explicit interlocutor and antagonist. Baudrillard in the background (disappearance of the real; seduction). Lévinas lurks behind the "Other." Adorno in the late melancholy. Han claims a distance from Frankfurt School institutional affiliation but his project is recognizably critical theory.

Intellectual Relationships Between the Seven (Synthesis)

The lineage as a chain of explicit citations:

- **McLuhan ← Innis** (the Toronto School; *Empire and Communications*, 1950).
- **Latour** rarely cites the others in this list; his interlocutors are STS (Bloor, Callon, Law). His concept of delegation does work analogous to McLuhan's "extensions of man" — both undo the human/tool boundary.
- **Marx ← Hegel, Feuerbach. Lukács extends Marx** (commodity fetishism → reification, *History and Class Consciousness*, 1923), and **Debord extends Lukács**. This is the most documented chain in the seven; Jappe's *Guy Debord* (1999) is the locus classicus.
- **Debord ← Lukács, Lefebvre, Marx, Hegel.** Debord's relation to Foucault is mutual non-citation despite Paris contemporaneity.
- **Foucault ← Nietzsche, Canguilhem, Bachelard.** Foucault read Marx with reservation; read Heidegger seriously in his late period.
- **Deleuze ← Foucault.** The Postscript explicitly continues *Discipline and Punish*; Deleuze's 1986 *Foucault* book and 1985–86 seminar prepare the ground. (Academia.edu + 2)
- **Han ← Heidegger, Foucault, Baudrillard, Hegel.** Han explicitly distinguishes himself from Foucault on the discipline/achievement break. (ArtReview)

Recommended Reading Order

Phase 1 — Primary texts in lineage order (~1,200 pages; do in this sequence):

1. Marx, *Capital* Vol. I, **chapter 1 only** (Fowkes trans., Penguin 1976), especially §4.
2. McLuhan, *Understanding Media* (1964), Part 1 (chs. 1-7); skim Part 2.
3. Debord, *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967), Knabb 2014/2024 translation — start with chapter 4 if chapter 1 is too dense (Knabb's own advice), then chapters 1-3. (DOKUMEN.PUB)
4. Foucault, *Discipline and Punish* (1975, Sheridan trans. 1977) — Part 3 "Discipline" and Part 4 "Prison" non-negotiable; the Panopticism chapter is core.
5. Latour, "Where Are the Missing Masses?" (1992) and "Mixing Humans and Nonhumans Together" (Jim Johnson, 1988) — together ~50 pages.
6. Deleuze, "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990, Joughin trans., *October* 59, 1992) — six pages; read three times.
7. Han, *Psychopolitics* (2014/2017); then *The Burnout Society* (2010/2015).

Phase 2 — Secondary literature that pays.

- Anselm Jappe, *Guy Debord* (California UP, 1999) — indispensable.
- Gilles Deleuze, *Foucault* (Minnesota, 1988).
- Georg Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness*, "Reification" essay (MIT Press, Livingstone trans., 1971).
- Foucault, *The Birth of Biopolitics* (Palgrave 2008) — to assess Han's claims.
- Raymond Williams, *Television: Technology and Cultural Form* (1974), pp. 126ff.
- Jürgen Habermas, *The Philosophical Discourse of Modernity* (MIT, 1987), Lectures IX-X.
- Latour, "Why Has Critique Run Out of Steam?" *Critical Inquiry* (2004).
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entries on Foucault, Marx, Debord (situationist), Deleuze, Lukács.

Phase 3 — Optional but rewarding.

- Latour, *Aramis, or the Love of Technology* (1996).
- Han, *In the Swarm* and *The Transparency Society*.

- Greil Marcus, *Lipstick Traces* (1989).
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Recommendations

1. **Lead the essay with the Marx-Debord pivot, not McLuhan-Latour.** McLuhan's "the medium is the message" is over-cited and risks sounding TED-talk. The Marx fetishism passage gives the moral charge: the apparatus is a frozen social relation, and there are *people* behind it.
 2. **Quote Foucault on "visibility is a trap" and pair it directly with Han on smart power.** Foucault: the prisoner cannot see the watcher. Han: the user cannot see the watcher because it has been replaced by a friendly interface mistaken for a mirror. The Ariel app is the apparatus that restores the watcher to view.
 3. **Use Deleuze's "self-deforming cast" as the design constraint.** If contemporary power is modulation, a static transparency dashboard will be inadequate; the app must itself modulate — surface the *current* face of the *current* decision, not a historical org chart. "Find new weapons" is the design brief.
 4. **Quote Latour's speed-bump passage as the founding metaphor.** The speed bump is the policeman whose face has been removed. Re-attaching the face is the design move.
 5. **Be honest about Han's limitations.** Acknowledge Alphin & Debrix's argument that Foucault's *Birth of Biopolitics* lectures already cover much of Han's terrain. This pre-empts the strongest objection.
 6. **Benchmarks that would change these recommendations.**
 - If the app's audience is primarily designers and product people, lean more heavily on Latour (concrete, methodological).
 - If the audience is primarily activists or critical-theory readers, lead with Debord and Han.
 - If you need to defend the app against the "this is paranoid" charge, the Foucault productivity-of-power material is your best resource: power is not a conspiracy but a relational structure, much harder to dismiss.
-

Caveats

- **The "lineage" is the user's analytical construct, not a historical fact.** None of these seven self-identified as part of a single tradition. Latour in particular would resist being placed with Debord or Marx. Present the chain as a *retrospective reconstruction*, not a documented genealogy.

- **The Culkin/McLuhan attribution error is widespread** and worth flagging in the essay itself. "As Culkin glossed McLuhan in 1967" is more accurate than the common misattribution and signals scholarly care.
- **Translation matters for Debord.** Knabb is most readable and accurate; Nicholson-Smith is more common in academic citations; Perlman/Black & Red is freely available online but rougher. State which you are using.
- **Han is a moving target.** He publishes a new book roughly annually, often re-stating earlier arguments. Treat *Psychopolitics* and *The Burnout Society* as canonical and reference later books only when they add a genuinely new concept.
- **Pagination for *Discipline and Punish*** differs across the 1977 Pantheon hardcover, the 1995 Vintage second edition, and the British Penguin edition; the Sheridan translation is the same but pagination differs. Cite consistently.
- **The Deleuze "Postscript" exists in two slightly different Joughin translations:** *October* 59 (1992), pp. 3-7, versus *Negotiations* (1995), pp. 177-182. Cite whichever edition you read; the title also shifts ("Societies of Control" vs. "Control Societies"). [\(Scribd\)](#)
- **Habermas's pagination** for the Foucault critique is cited from the MIT Press / Polity Lawrence translation (1987); the Polity (UK) and MIT (US) editions may differ slightly. Lectures IX & X, pp. 238-293, with the "presentistic, relativistic, cryptonormative" formulation at pp. 275-276.